

Young Authors

anthology

Fall 2025

an anthology written by
4th and 5th grade students
in the Washoe County area



Young Author's Anthology

A Collection of 4th and 5th Grade Short Stories

Fall 2025

Project Team

Ishan Panda, Kentia Kalanaki, Kylee D., Keizou Wang,

Ethan Ahn, Myla Clemetsen, L. Lambert

And Everyone Who Holds This Book Currently

To Angie Bryan, Samantha Shoolroy, Tasha Holcomb, Angela Orr, Amy Piper,
Torrey Palmer, Gia Maraccini, Dawn Dupont, and Lucy Borsz

Thank you for giving us this book

Editors' Note

The goal of this project will always be to encourage more people to start writing. In our English classes, we're instructed to make carefully thought-out essays using evidence from the text to formulate our responses. The rationale for this practice is to measure the merit of our literary skills. The unfortunate consequence of this practice is the implication that our creative stories, based on no supporting evidence, fictitious quotes, and made-up events, are not proper metrics of our literary skills, when the opposite is often true. Every student who submitted to this program showed dedication, passion, technique, and imagination when writing their stories, and they should all be congratulated for it.

It may feel discouraging to not see your writing among the selected winners for this semester's anthology. However, that would be mistaken. No literary work can be judged objectively, even against our best attempts to do so. While we have some criteria for judging these works based on prose, originality, and general depth and impact of the story, by no means do these metrics sufficiently measure a writer's ability.

Your work that you sent, whether it entered here or not, set the bar for the thirteen stories that were selected. We strongly encourage everyone who participated in this competition to continue writing, to use this book as inspiration, and to not stop writing. Not just because this competition will run again next semester, but because the difference between a good writer and a bad writer is how long they persist and hone their skills across their life, not across this book.

As such, it only makes sense to have the section below list the names of every entrant who did not opt to be listed as anonymous.

List of Entrants

Aaron, Abby, Abigail Buescher, Abraham, Abril, Adrian (4th grade; Mater), Adrian (5th grade ; Mater), Aeyana, Aeyana Samantha Ryan, Aiden, Alainah, Aldo, Alina, Altana, Alyssa, Alyssa, Amaury, Amy, Andres, Anna, Annali, Anoop Bath, Arantza, Arpan Dash, Asher, Azari, Bo, Brianna, Brody, Brookelynn, Caelieb, Camilia, Carlos, Cata, Celeste, Christopher, Dahlilah, Dakota, Dalilah, Damaris, Daniel, Daniel, Darlyne, David, Denis, Dezirei, Dheeraj Kolla, Drew Meier, Echo, Elias, Emily, Emmett Herrera, Enilah, Eron, Ezequiel, Felicity Coulombe, Frankie, Gael, Grey, Harper Jensen, Henry Rogovy, Hitse, Isaac, Jack Hanrahan, Jaylah, Jazmine, Jennifer Pauline Miller, Jimena, Jose, Julian, Kaia Duque, Katherine, Kathryn, Kaylee, Kelvin, Knox, Kristen, Laly, Layla, Leilani, Leonel, Lexie, Liliana, Lincoln Kirkwood, Lorenzo Cantu, Luis, Macario, Madeline Stephenson, Mairen Hamiester, Malia, Manuel Dominquez, Marcus, Marjory, Mary, Matthew, Matthew Madden, Matti Nyrhinen Max, MeShell, Mia, Mieke Jimetta, Milo, Moises, Naira, Naomi, Natalie, Nellie, Nestor, Nicholas, Nico, Nirvana, Nivia, Noah (Mater), Noah Johnson, Oliver, Paityn, Pedro, Preston, Rose, Ruben, Samuel Ignatich, Sofia, Soren Astrup, Stephen, Tyler G., Valentina, Victor, Vlad, William, Yaretzi, Yelson, Yumiko, Zoe, Zowie

Contact Info: ipanda@davidsonacademy.unr.edu

Winners

In No Particular Order

Felicity Coulombe | Brown Elementary

Diary of a Dog.....Page 9

Felicity lives in Reno, Nevada, with her dog, Luna. Luna is the reason she wrote this book, and Luna inspires Felicity. Luna is an English Black Labrador Retriever. She is friendly, and she is such a great dog and Felicity loves her.

Matthew Madden | Hunsberger Elementary

Time Traveler.....Page 17

Matthew is in 4th grade at Hunsberger Elementary. He is enrolled in the SWAS program. Matthew enjoys reading and doing art. Matthew has a family who lives in China, so he visits there when he gets the chance. He is curious about how the world works.

Tyler G. | Mater Academy

Bee and Butterfly.....Page 20

My favorite colors are black and red. I wrote this story just for fun and I thought by reading it, it would make someone's day. I would like to thank my teacher Mrs. Dupont, and my mom for helping me come up with my story.

Lorenzo Cantu | Mater Academy

The Great Light.....Page 22

My name is Lorenzo Cantu. I am 11 years old, and I'm a 5th grader at Mater Academy of Northern Nevada. Outside of school, I love to draw anime and create fun doodles. I started enjoying writing when I was about 7 years old, and I especially like adding drawings that go along with my stories. It helps bring my ideas to life!

Harper Jensen | Hunsberger Elementary

Draco the Baby Dragon.....Page 24

Harper is a 4th grader at Hunsberger Elementary School. She is enrolled in the SWAS program. She loves Garfield and dogs. Harper loves to read and is interested in creating Kandy (beaded creations). She is kind and loves her friends!

Winners

In No Particular Order

Drew Meier and Mairén Hamiester Doral Academy

Homerun!Page 26

We were inspired to write this story in honor the the people in our lives that survived cancer. We wanted to also display friendship throughout this story as it mirrors our friendship. Finally, we wanted to include baseball because it is Drew's favorite sport. Drew and Marien have been friends for almost two years. They are in 5th grade at Doral Academy of Northern Nevada. When they met each other, they immediately noticed that they had a love for poetry, writing and they are both silly. Drew and Marien became fast friends and made sure that friendship was a theme in their story. Homerun!

Anoop Bath | Hunsberger Elementary

The Adventures of a Dinosaur Nerd.....Page 29

Anoop Bath was born in Hillsboro, Oregon. He is nine years old, has a younger brother who is five years old, and a baby sister who is one. His favorite animal is the African Lion. He also loves building Lego sets at home. His favorite video game is Minecraft, and his favorite book is Fantastic Mr. Fox by Roald Dahl. The reason behind his writing interest is that he loves dinosaurs, and he knows a lot of facts about them.

Kelvin Merino Varona | Mater Academy

Jimmy Jim's AdventurePage 33

My name is Kelvin Merino Varona, and I am 10 years old. Outside of school, I love playing soccer, helping my mom, and playing video games. I first started to enjoy writing when I was in 2nd grade, and ever since then I've liked expressing my ideas and stories on paper!

Lincoln Kirkwood | Hunsberger Elementary

The Interglacial War.....Page 35

Lincoln is a 4th grader at Hunsberger Elementary School. He is enrolled in the SWAS program. He has a younger brother. When he is not in school, he loves to play board games, card games, and sports outdoors. He also enjoys video games. Lincoln is currently reading the Harry Potter series and is enjoying it.

Winners

In No Particular Order

Margaret “Maggie” Reed | Doral Academy

Just Do ItPage 38

My name is Maggie. I'm only 10 and have dreamed of being an author since a young age. My inspiration for this book is my personal experiences. I play softball and started off with a lack of confidence. After 5 years of practicing, I'm better at softball. The lesson is: only when you stop trying, do you truly fail.

Sofia Ruelas | Mater Academy

Alice and the Magical WitchPage 43

My name is Sofia Ruelas. I am 11 years old, and I'm a 5th grader at Mater Academy of Northern Nevada. Outside of school, I enjoy creating art and playing soccer. I had a lot of fun writing this story in class, and I'm excited for you to read it.

Emmett Herrera | Mater Academy

An Unfortunate Camping TripPage 45

I was nine when writing this story. I wrote this story because I thought it would be funny. I like to play baseball, and my favorite color is red. I want to thank my vice principal, Ms. Torrey, and my teacher, Mrs. Dupont, for helping me to succeed in this contest.

Mieko Jimetta | Mater Academy

Sakura and the Dragon's VillagePage 47

My name is Mieko Jimetta. I am 10 years old and I am a 5th grader at Mater Academy of Northern Nevada. Outside of school I like to read Japanese comics and make different items such as scarves, dolls and things out of paper. A cool fact about me is that I can read, write, and speak Japanese!

Foreword: These short stories have been edited for any minor content, grammar, formatting, or structural issues.

Diary of a Dog

By Felicity Coulombe



Felicity's dog, Luna

June 23, 2021

Dear Diary,

Hi, I am Luna. My birthday was today, and I met a dog who recommended that I should get a diary, so here I am writing my first words. I got so many gifts and treats and ate so much that I nearly threw up. My big mommy is Kirsten, but my real mommy (little mommy) is Felicity. Well, her name is Felicity, but her friends call her Fi-Fi. So, anyway, I woke up this morning, and little Mommy was in my face and said, "Happy Birthday!"

I looked at her, thinking, "Huh." She told me I was 1-year-old, and I ran into the kitchen and saw a breakfast bigger than I had ever seen, so I licked my chops and dived in. After breakfast, I was so full. I took a nap, but not just any nap. It was the best nap ever! I dreamt that

I was on a flying unicorn who was also dreaming. It was so cool! When I woke up, I went to go bye-bye in the car (I slept in the car). When the car stopped, I got out and had the time of my life at my birthday party! I met so many new dogs and ate special dog cake. I also got to play in the pool! It was really fun.

July 31, 2021

Dear Diary,

Today was my first day camping. I went bye-bye in the car for a long time! When we got there, there was a ginormous pool that had fish in it. Big Mommy exclaimed, "Look at the lake!"

Of course, I didn't know what a lake was, so I had called it a ginormous pool. A couple of seconds later, my little Mommy came and hopped in with me. I swam so fast and far that when I came back, they put me on a leash. This was a long leash, however, so I could swim far, but I would not go out of their sight. When I was done swimming, I walked back to the campsite with my girls.

August 1, 2021

Dear Diary,

This morning, I went on so many walks, and I sniffed so many new smells. It was great. I also met a new friend, and he recommended that I should try to watch television. Whatever that is. I'll try it when I get back from camping.

Today was a great day. I am wet and tired, so I will talk to you later.

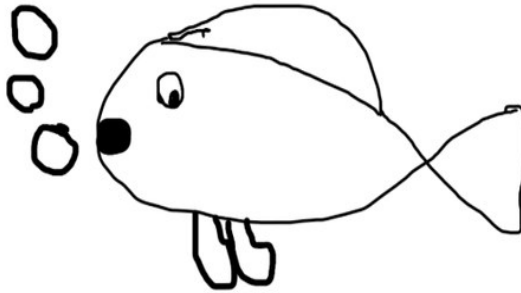
August 3, 2021

Dear Diary,

I woke up this morning and went to my little Mommy's bedroom. I woke her up by jumping up on her bed and burping in her face. She slowly walked to the kitchen and turned on the television, and I watched it for the first time ever. I loved it! It was so cool. I watched these dancing dogs that were blue and orange. Now, I'll watch it every day with little Mommy. But when she left the house someone else came through the door, and that was Grandpa. He came with this big bucket of water that smelled funny; I loved it. Something was moving inside, and it splashed me. It was orange, with a long tail.

My little Mommy said, “Thank you for helping me.”

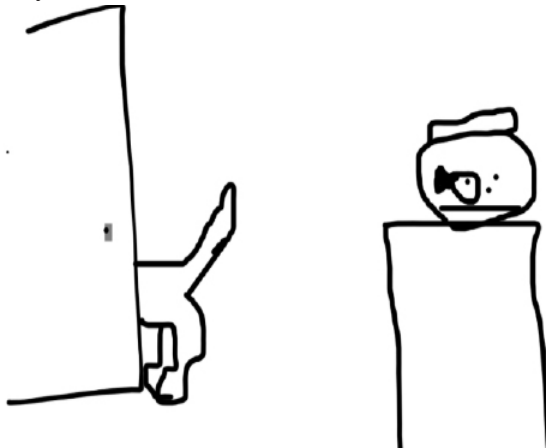
I looked inside and saw a big orange fish. Then, little and big Mommy left the room. I looked at the fish one more time and then walked away.



August 16, 2021

Dear Diary,

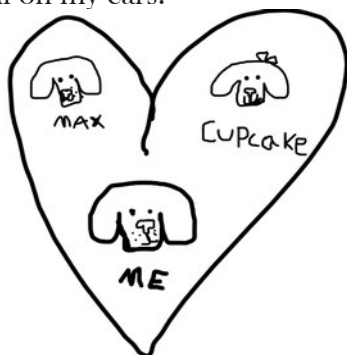
It has been awhile since I have talked to you. Well, that is because I have been busy. The fish has a home in my little Mommy’s bedroom, and I had to stay at Nana’s house because my girls went on a trip and I forgot my diary. It has been a handful over the past few days; I will take a break from writing again. I hope to talk to you soon but for now this is fairwell and goodbye.



March 1, 2022

Dear Diary,

I have been doing well this past year. Since my last entry, I had puppies! Their names are Joey, Sally, Marcus, Booboo, Max, Maddie, and Cupcake. The two puppies that I kept are Cupcake and Max. They are my life; I love them so much. The only time they are a handful is when they bite and pull on my ears.



March 3, 2022

Dear Diary,

Hi, I am Cupcake, and I am writing in Mommy's journal. If you did not know already, I am her wonderful most wonderful most amazing puppy that she has ever had.

Hey party people, this is Max. I am clearly Mommy's favorite, not Cupcake.

Cupcake again, and I would like to say that I am Mommy's favorite because I am older.

This is Max, again. I would also like to say that I lost my first tooth today, and that means I am, in fact, older.

Hi! I'm back. I am so sorry for my kids writing in my diary. They can be a bit much sometimes. I have to put them to bed, so talk to you tomorrow.

March 4, 2022

Dear Diary,

Today, the kids are spending the day at Nana's house, so I have the day to myself! I am so relaxed that I am taking a lot of naps and

watching television with little Mommy. She is turning eleven tomorrow. I love having family time with her, especially before her birthday. Little Mommy told me that, tomorrow, she would take me to the dog park with Max and Cupcake. I cannot wait!

Yesterday, the kids got into the trash, and big Mommy was so mad. She wanted to throw them in the dungeon... but we don't have one. So, I was so confused...

March 5, 2022

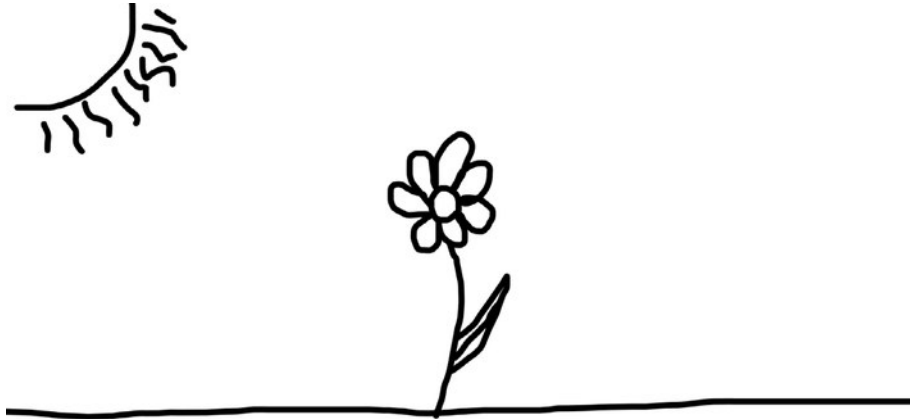
Dear Diary,

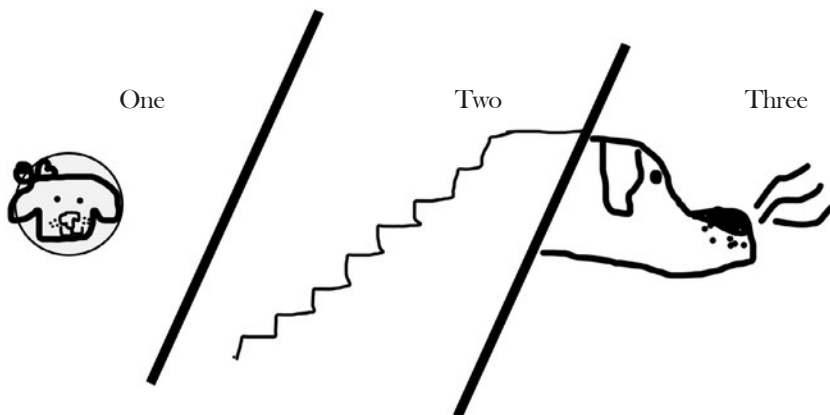
Today, I am taking the kids to the dog park. They finally got all of their puppy shots, so this is a great way to introduce them to other dogs! They woke up this morning so happy to go to the dog park. They even skipped breakfast! What dog would skip breakfast? I guess they really wanted to go. I'll see you later, bye!

April 1, 2022

Dear Diary,

It is the first day of spring today: all of the flowers are blooming, the sun is shining, birds are chirping, and everything is perfect. Almost. You see, we just found out Cupcake is sick, and she has to lie in bed while Max, big Mommy, little Mommy, and I are playing. Do not tell Cupcake, whoever might be reading this, but for a little get-better-soon gift, I got her a pig ear! She hasn't tried on before, but they are delicious!





May 29, 2022

Dear Diary,

Last week, we went to the Grand Canyon, and we saw a horse that looked like a donkey. His name was Mule. Then, we saw a really fast bird called a roadrunner, I do not know why it is called this because it did not run on the road, he ran on the desert ground. We had a whole trip designated to going bye-bye in the car. The trip was so fun! The best part was going to Handle's Ice Cream and getting a pup cup. When Max and Cupcake got a pup cup, they got the zoomies (they became hyper and moved erratically) around the backyard.

June 5, 2022

Dear Diary,

Today, my dog friend, Lincoln, came over, and Max and Cupcake went coo-coo. They ran all over the house, and then Lincoln chased after them. After a while they became friends. They slept on top of each other for a long time, and then Lincoln went home. Max and Cupcake were sad, but I told them that it was okay and that we would see him again.

June 7, 2022

Dear Diary,

Hi Mommy's diary, this is Cupcake. I'm here to tell you that I... cannot find my mommy Luna. Max and I have looked everywhere for her, but we cannot find her. Little Mommy and big Mommy are so worried. Max and I sleep in her dog bed these nights, hoping she will come back.

Hi Mommy's journal or diary, whatever this is. This is Max, and

I saw that my sister Cupcake has already told you about my mommy. I really hope she comes back soon. I'm so worried. The last time we saw her was June 5th, but now she's gone.

Cupcake again... I would like to say that we are moving houses in just one week. I really hope she will be back by then. Otherwise, she won't find us, and then she would be worried about us, and we'd never get her back.

It's Max again. I think she will be back in time, but I'm still worried. Cupcake and I will go look for her now, so goodbye. We'll find her.

June 9, 2022

Dear Diary,

Hi, Cupcake here. We are moving in five days. I am worried sick about my mom. So are big Mommy and little Mommy. They put out signs in human writing that said "Lost" with a picture of my Mommy, Luna, on the sign. They also put a bunch of numbers to get in contact for whoever finds my Mommy. I don't know how humans do it, but if it will get my Mommy back, I'll go with it.

Hey there, it's Max. We don't have any clues still as to where she is. But, since we are moving soon, we need to find her. There is still hope, but the whole family is getting more nervous in case we don't get her back. We're going to keep looking for her, so talk to you later.

June 13, 2022

Dear Diary,

Max here. We're moving in a few hours. All of us are so worried about my Mommy, and we still cannot find her. She's completely gone. I guess we won't see her again.

Wait a second...

June 13, 2022

Hi! It's Luna. I came running from the bushes when I saw the truck! Oh diary, how I have missed you.

I bet you are wondering how I went missing. Well, I saw a stray cat in the backyard, so I went running after it when everyone else was

asleep. I chased the cat into the woods and over the river. It took a few days. Then, I finally cornered it when, in the distance, I heard a howl like a dog, but it was louder than any dog. I turned around, trying to see what it was, but the cat suddenly ran away. I heard that howl again and again.

Then, it stopped.

When I came across the end of the river, I saw it. A wolf was standing there, so I ran back home as fast as I could. I reached here right before the truck left. I'm happy to be back, and, hopefully, I can update this diary when we move into the next house.

Goodbye. - Luna
Bye - bye. - Cupcake
See yah! - Max.

The END!!!



Felicity lives in Reno, Nevada, with her dog, Luna. Luna is the reason she wrote this book, and Luna inspires Felicity. Luna is an English Black Labrador Retriever. She is friendly, and she is such a great dog and Felicity loves her.

Congratulations Felicity!

Time Traveler

By Matthew Madden

“I am a time traveler, and I will be going 65,000,000 years into the past to see dinosaurs.”

My elevator goes to the core of the Earth where my bunker, containing my time-traveling device, is located. It is located inside of my house, requires a secret code, and, while it goes extremely fast, it still takes a while to get to the core. As I get closer to the elevator, I take a good look around at the room. It's in complete disarray, but, after looking closer, I realized that my time-traveling device was still there. Only after thinking it through, I concluded that my brother, Thomas, must have done this. I went about fixing up the room but noticed that the time travel device was already on. Angrily, I knew that Thomas had gone back in time. Knowing that there was nothing I could do at the moment, I went to bed.

When I woke up the next morning, I was no longer in my room. I was lying on a patch of grass near a tree. To get a better view, I climbed up the tree where I saw a campfire. Boldly, I yelled “Are you there?”

“Yes! I am here,” a voice echoed back to me. Instinctively, I knew it was Thomas.

I climbed down from the tree and ran to the campfire where Thomas's voice must have been coming from. I heard a noise behind me, and that was when I understood that I had time traveled. How, you ask? Because a velociraptor was chasing me! Miraculously, I made it to the campfire where I saw Thomas.

“RUN!” I yelled to Thomas as the velociraptor came nearer.

We ran for what felt like miles until we were sure that the dinosaur was no longer chasing us.

As we made our way back to Thomas's camp, I decided I'd go looking for more dinosaurs, since that's the reason I wanted to travel back in time anyways. As I made my way into the forest, I heard a chomping noise not too far away. I went to explore and found two velociraptors dining on some poor animal. I tried to sneak up on them, but my foot hovered over a fallen tree branch before making a loud-

CRACK!

The velociraptors immediately looked up, and, after seeing fresh meat, started chasing me. While running, I got the idea to hide behind a tree and try to stun the dinosaurs. I grabbed the nearest stick I could find, praying that my plan would work! As the dinosaurs stalked past my hiding spot, I jammed the stick into one of their backs.

"ROAR!" The dinosaur's screams resonated through the forest.

The second velociraptor took their friend's screams as a threat and started attacking them. This allowed me to run back to camp and tell Thomas about my adventure.

"You would not believe what I just saw!" I exclaimed when Thomas came into view. I explained my story to him and then added, **"Let's go find a T-Rex now!"**

"Are you crazy?" Thomas shrieked.

"I mean, I guess you could just stay here then," I replied.

"Ugh! I guess I'll tag along," Thomas sighed.

"Let's go hunt a T-Rex!" I said excitedly.

After about 2 hours of searching, we were about to give up when we saw what we were looking for. A T-Rex! At the exact moment we saw the dinosaur, he saw us and started chasing us. I decided that if my plan for the velociraptors worked, then I would try the same thing for the T-Rex. I boldly picked up a

sharp rock and hid behind a tree. When he got close enough to us, I threw the rock at his eye, and **BULLSEYE!** The T-Rex started howling in pain, giving Thomas and I a chance to escape. As we got back to the campsite, we activated the time machine to go back home.

The next morning I woke up safe and sound in my bed, wondering if it had all been a dream. The only confirmations that it had been real were the grass stuck to the bottoms of my shoes and the smell of campfire on my clothes. I sighed in relief and went to find Thomas.

“That was some adventure,” I admitted to Thomas as I walked into his room.

“It sure was, but let’s never do it again!” Thomas remarked.

“I couldn’t agree more,” I agreed. Then, I went back into my room to fall asleep for a very long time.



Matthew is in 4th grade at Hunsberger Elementary. He is enrolled in the SWAS program. Matthew enjoys reading and doing art. Matthew has a family who lives in China, so he visits there when he gets the chance. He is curious about how the world works.

Congratulations Matthew!

Bee and Butterfly

By Tyler G.

Flying high above the garden lived the bee and the butterfly. The bee, named Bee, worked hard collecting nectar, bark, and leaves.

The bark is to seal off cracks in her nest.
The leaves are for blankets.
The nectar is for food.

Every time the butterfly, named Butterfly, saw Bee working hard, she said, “Why work when you can show off? You are beautiful after all. Try it!”

Bee said, “You should be preparing for winter. There will not be any food left, and you will be cold!”

Butterfly said, “Come on, winter is months away! You should loosen up!”

Bee said, “I wish I could, but I am too busy with collecting nectar, bark, and leaves for winter... You should too!”

“No!” yelled Butterfly. “I will not work!”

“Butterfly, you must work, or you will have no food, and you will be cold during winter!” Said Bee.

Butterfly flew off to go show off her wings, completely ignoring Bee. Bee yelled out, “You need to prepare and stop showing off your wings!”

Butterfly yelled, “No!” while still flying away.

Months passed and winter arrived. Butterfly was not prepared. Her home was cold, and she had no food, so she was starving. So, she flew to Bee’s house. Butterfly asked Bee if she had any extra food, leaves, or bark. Bee had prepared for this

and said, “yes.” Bee gave her some extra leaves, bark, and just enough food to survive the winter.

Butterfly said, “Thank you, I now know to prepare, and I will help you from now on!” and flew off. Bee watched as Butterfly flew away feeling proud of teaching Butterfly a very important lesson:

Butterfly now knows for next time to prepare but still have fun! Now Butterfly will prepare for the colder months.



My favorite colors are black and red. I wrote this story just for fun and I thought by reading it, it would make someone's day. I would like to thank my teacher Mrs. Dupont, and my mom for helping me come up with my story.

Congratulations Tyler!

The Great Light

By Lorenzo Cantu

In a distant land there was a beautiful village where the huts were many different colors. One day, an illness started to spread, and all the color drained as everything worsened. But a young man named Sen was not sick. He tried everything to lift this curse from his village, but every herb and medicine failed.

One day, sitting by a stump, a man asked, "Would you do anything to save your village?"

Sen said, "yes," trying to hide the nervousness. "I would do anything," he said.

"Then, meet me at the great temple," said the man.

When Sen went to the temple, the man appeared again. "You will have three tasks to do to save your village. If you fail any of these tasks, you will be turned to stone," said the man. "Your first task is to put these three magical stones into the three holes at the forest gate, but the stones are scattered," said the man. Then, he disappeared.

Right when the man disappeared, Sen got to looking. He found two stones hiding in a tree, but the third one was with a very old man. Sen asked the old man for the stone, but the old man said the stone was a rock that held his wife's ashes. Sen asked the man if he would trade a gold bowl for the rock of ashes. The old man was delighted and agreed to place the ashes in the bowl. He emptied the stone, and the trade was fair. Sen placed the three stones in the glowing holes.

"So, you've passed the first task. Now go on to the next one," said the man. The man then guided Sen into the forest and past the gate.

Before them sat a family who were starving and thirsty. Before thinking, Sen grabbed a water bottle from his jacket

and gave it to them. After the family had water, Sen asked what happened. The oldest child said that a terrible storm destroyed their house and food supply, so they had nothing for three days. They tried to catch fish, but no luck. Sen decided then to give them food. The family was overjoyed, so they led Sen to the castle.

When Sen reached the castle, he was told by the man to climb to the top of the tower. While he was almost at the top of the tower, he realized that this whole time he was only showing kindness, and that same kindness got him here. Sen then reached the top of the tower, huffing and puffing. The man appeared. “You have shown that your village deserves to be healed. Because of your kindness, I give you a wish,” said the man.

“I wish for my village to be healed from the color-draining sickness,” said Sen. “Your wish is granted,” the man said. On the way to the village, he saw his family more happy than ever. In the end his kindness was rewarded.



My name is Lorenzo Cantu. I am 11 years old, and I'm a 5th grader at Mater Academy of Northern Nevada. Outside of school, I love to draw anime and create fun doodles. I started enjoying writing when I was about 7 years old, and I especially like adding drawings that go along with my stories. It helps bring my ideas to life!

Congratulations Lorenzo!

Draco the Baby Dragon

By Harper Jensen

“I’m never leaving you alone again,” said the singsong voice of what could only be a mother.

* * *

Once upon a time, there was a baby dragon named Draco. He was a very, very rare dragon. He had emerald horns and a red body. He was three years old and had a mother named Eliza. Eliza doted on Draco. They were the only two dragons of their kind left after Eliza’s partner was killed when Draco was just a few months old. Currently, they live in the clouds.

One day, Draco and Eliza were playing catch with a ball.

“Oh sweetie, I just remembered I need to go water the plants! I must first go fill the canteen with rainwater from the cloud next door. I’ll be just a minute,” Eliza shouted as she ran inside.

While Draco was left alone, he continued playing with the ball until he got bored. That’s when he decided to take a walk. While on his walk, he must have slipped on a patch of cloud ice, because when he woke up, he was lying on his back with a massive headache.

“W-what happened? My head hurts!” Draco thought to himself as he tried to stand up. The next thing he knew, a white van flew towards him, opened the side door, and somebody dragged him inside. As soon as the door shut, the van went at full speed with Draco inside.

“Ha! Dumb kid,” retorted the man who grabbed Draco. Draco thought he resembled a unicorn. Once Draco realized the reality that he was in, tears started streaming down his face as he thought he may never see his mom again.

About two hours later, Draco was sitting alone in a dark, damp room when he came up with an idea! He’d had plenty of time to scout out the place he was being held, and he noticed a few windows. Draco had also noticed that there were sharp rocks or stones lying around the room as well. His plan was that he was going to ask the kidnapper (dragon-napper?) for

some water, and while he was retrieving the water, Draco would escape through one of the windows. What if the napper said no, though? Draco realized that he had to at least try. He waited 20 more minutes before gathering up the courage to test his plan.

“Umm...Excuse me? Sir...Or ma’am?” Draco asked uncertainly.

“What do you want kid?” replied a low, deep voice.

“May I have some water...please?” Draco asked hopefully.

“I guess a kid has gotta drink,” the man said. “Don’t do anything silly while I’m gone, you hear? Mark my words!” He added hesitantly and got up to leave.

Once Draco was sure the man had gone and couldn’t hear anything, he jumped up and smashed a window into shards. He immediately scrambled out without hesitation, and as his feet hit the ground, he started running without looking back. Draco ran as fast and as far as his 3-year-old feet could carry him until he felt safe enough to fly up into the clouds.

He landed somewhere near his home in the clouds, and as he got closer to his home, he spotted his tearful mom talking with police officers. He ran up to his mother, hugged her, and explained what had happened. Eliza looked at Draco and gasped:

“I’m never leaving you alone again!”



Harper is a 4th grader at Hunsberger Elementary School. She is enrolled in the SWAS program. She loves Garfield and dogs. Harper loves to read and is interested in creating Kandy (beaded creations). She is kind and loves her friends!

Congratulations Harper!

Homerun!

By Drew Meier and Mairén Hamiester

On a small farm in Mandrogi, Russia, were two kids. One a short, dirty blond boy named Rio who loves baseball, and the other, a tall, blonde girl named Mia who loves to play softball and loves everything nature-related.

These individuals are both friends and have a house in the middle of their farm, which has exactly enough space to fit two families, with one bedroom for every person to live there. Both Mia's and Rio's families owned this farm, alone, in the middle of the wilderness. They were the only people who lived on the farm because they owned it. Mia's mom was an educated doctor in New Orleans and quit to live in the forest.

Mia and Rio had been spending less time than usual playing baseball together because they needed more food, and they had to harvest. When they got the chance to play baseball in the woods again, it had already been four months.

Since they started harvesting, Mia and Rio have been working on a new wooden baseball bat, and they are now almost finished with it. When Halloween hit, they started sewing, and, when they were done, they showed their costumes off to each other. Russian holidays do not include Halloween, but they really wanted to go to America at the time, so they would pretend that they were in America.

They both loved engineering, so they made a robot that could do a variety of things, which included doing their chores and farming food for them. Over the next few days, the parents tried to hide that they were getting tired of farming. When Rio and Mia figured this out, they told their parents about the robot, and the parents were pleased. A couple weeks later, Rio and Mia went into the woods and played a game of baseball, which Mia won. Rio declared a rematch, but they didn't know that there would be no rematch. When they were walking, Mia started to complain. First about having a headache, then achy joints,

and then she started to feel lightheaded. Mia uttered something like "wa-it" before she fell to the ground and passed out.

When Rio realized that Mia had passed out, he rushed her to her mom, and her mom soon realized that Mia had cancer. When Mia woke up, she only saw clouds of grey for people and things. For the next two hours, things didn't change until the next morning.

When she woke up again, she could see clearly and had very faint signs of another headache. A couple of weeks later Mia found herself doing a lot better, but Rio was still horrified at the thought of him losing his own friend and his only friend. While this happened, their parents tried to find a cure for people with cancer.

They were successful, and when Mia started to use it, it was really doing its job. When Mia was strong enough to walk again, she started spending every second of every day with Rio, and they loved it. All the walking that they were doing together was helping Mia's legs gain strength. Even though Mia was healing fast, Mia started getting scared too that she might not live for too long, and she wanted to fulfill her promise that if she died, they would be on a baseball field together.

Rio said to her, "You won't pass away; you'll live."

When Mia went to sleep, Rio wanted to have a surprise for her when she woke up. So, he started to make a small homemade baseball field out of sticks and pine tar. When Mia woke up, she was in disbelief about the baseball field right next to their house, and when she asked who made it, she was once again in disbelief about Rio making it by himself. She immediately asked if they could play baseball, and Rio said,

"That's what I made it for." Rio went easy on Mia the whole time, but Mia still felt as if she were playing a regular softball game and loved it. Mia won the game and asked to play again, but Rio lied and said he was tired just to keep Mia as healthy as she was then.

The next morning, Mia felt her legs cramping because of the baseball game. She couldn't walk anymore, so her parents made her a wheelchair and told her not to try to walk anymore until her legs felt better. Two weeks later, Mia and Rio were going to go on a walk through the forest, and when they were ready to leave, Mia went to her room to get water. When she came out, she was walking again!

Rio nearly thought that she had forgotten she needed her wheelchair and stood up to reach her water on the top shelf.

Everyone was happy that her legs had healed. She was now cancer-free and went back to playing baseball on the weekends. They did not expect any more injuries that bad for a long time after that, and they thought completely right. For two more years, they lived happy lives with no injuries and no more complaints coming from either of them. Their parents passed away, and they moved to America and both got married to girl and boy twins before having babies one month apart from each other.

When they turned 50, their kids were already 5 and 6 years old and wished to someday have a friendship like Mia and Rio's friendship. Their kids were very good friends from then to the end of their lives and moved to a farm in Mexico when they had kids of their own, and for centuries these friendships went on, and for centuries more of these friendships never stopped, and they always trusted each other with their hearts.

Every century of kids turning into grown-ups never had an adventure like Mia and Rio's Journey. The farm that Rio and Mia's kids moved to was the place that their families would forever stay, and the place where their journey through hard times and persistence would be told for years on.



We were inspired to write this story in honor the the people in our lives that survived cancer. We wanted to also display friendship throughout this story as it mirrors our friendship. Finally, we wanted to include baseball because it is Drew's favorite sport. Drew and Marien have been friends for almost two years. They are in 5th grade at Doral Academy of Northern Nevada. When they met each other, they immediately noticed that they had a love for poetry, writing and they are both silly. Drew and Marien became fast friends and made sure that friendship was a theme in their story, Homerun!

Congratulations Drew and Mairien!

The Adventures of a Dinosaur Nerd

By Anoop Bath

Chapter One: Dino Nerd

On Friday, October 10, 2030, dinosaurs took over this uncharted, unknown island surrounded by water. On the island are thick jungle trees and other vegetation. On the edge of the island is a sandy beach with one tall palm tree.

The island is in the middle of the Atlantic Ocean. Some of the animals that are in the ocean around the island are the Port Jackson Shark, Box Jellyfish, Mandarin Fish, Clownfish, the Moray Eel, and the Dugong (a Manatee-like creature). Some of the birds that are around the island are the Osprey, the Sooty Tern, and the Pacific Reef Egret (also known as reef herons).

There are a lot of dinosaurs on this island, but the mightiest is the Tyrannosaurus Rex (T-rex). Its name means the Tyrant Lizard. Its length is 40 ft! It is a carnivorous (meat-eating) dinosaur.

The smell of ocean water wafted through the jungle air. Meanwhile, there was only one survivor on the entire island! His name was...Sam! He has dark brown hair and light brown eyes. He wears a blue pair of jeans and a red t-shirt. He is 8 years old. There is a big red button located in the middle of the island guarded by two big, ferocious dinosaurs! That big red button will make all the dinos disappear! Sam has a journal of all the behaviors of the dinosaurs that lived on the island. "Look!" Sam said, "The dinosaurs are sleeping. Now is my chance!"

Sam raced toward the button, but the dinosaurs woke up...

"Well, add that to the journal," Sam muttered. "Great hearing."

Chapter Two: The Battle

Sam decided he needed a dinosaur companion to help him fight the two big dinos. So, he went to the edge of the island where the T-rexes roam. After days of searching, he found a baby T-rex. Sam thought a baby T-rex would be easier to train than an adult. He named him Jordan.

Finally, after 10 years of training Jordan; Sam did it!

He trained a T-rex! Sam gathered his weapons, and he and his companion set out to the two big dinos. The T-rex was now fully grown. Sam's companion stopped behind two big bushes. There they were: the two big dinosaurs.

The dinos have names: one is Elon, and one is Musk. Sam decided to do the smart thing and try to go behind them. They were now right behind Elon and Musk. Sam and Jordan waited for the right time, and then...they burst out through the bushes to the big red button! Of course, Elon and Musk heard, but Sam shot Musk with a tranquilizer dart, and Musk went to sleep. While Jordan and Elon were fighting, Jordan had the upper hand, and Sam snuck behind Elon! He was at the big red button, but since the button was too big for his hands, he used his sledgehammer. Finally, after years of prepping and fighting, Sam and Jordan did it!

Chapter Three: The Civilization

All the dinosaurs disappeared except for Jordan.

Why? Sam and Jordan have a special relationship with each other. Sam had outstanding swimming prowess because his mother had that ability too. So, he swam all the way to the United States! Sam told everybody about the unknown, uncharted island and how he and Jordan saved the island. When people started moving there, they were scared of Jordan. However, when Sam said that Jordan was his pet, they felt better. Sam had started a civilization, and it was Sam's responsibility to keep it alive.

Chapter Four: The New Leader

80 years later...Sam is 98 years old now, and he does not know how he is going to keep the village alive! He asked his assistant what he should do, and his assistant said, "You should hand over the responsibility to a person that you find that you can trust." Sam did just that. He set off through the island to find someone that is worthy of the responsibility. He saw this small hut on the side of the road. Sam knocked on the door, and a poor boy answered the door. Sam looked inside the hut, and it was all messy. Sam left. Then Sam found a sturdy brick house. He knocked on the door, and a decent young man answered the door. Sam entered the house. It was a cozy, welcoming house. The young man offered Sam something to drink, and Sam chose milk.

Chapter Five: The Criminal

That was when Sam asked the young man if he could handle the responsibility of taking care of a civilization. When the man answered yes, Sam took him back to the community. On the way to the community, the young man said his name was Arthur. When Arthur and Sam got back, all of the residents that lived in the community were gone! Then, someone came out of a wooden barrel. It was a living resident! The living resident said that his name was Jake, and he was the only one left. “A mysterious person took the people in bags and got away!” Jake said.

Sam said to Arthur, “You stay and guard this village until I get back.”

Chapter Six: The Journey

Sam set off into the jungle once again with Jordan to find this “mysterious person who stole everyone.” Sam found a trapdoor in an outhouse right next to the broken big red button, so he and Jordan went through it. Once underground, they were inside the outhouse. Sam and Jordan secretly snuck behind the security guards and to a ginormous vault! They needed a key to unlock it; just then Sam noticed a key on one of the guards’ belts. Sam tranquilized both of the guards and took the key.

Chapter Seven: The Thief Uncovered

Sam opened the vault, and inside were all the lost citizens! The vault was left extra cold to freeze the people to death. Sam quickly pulled them out, then put them into the sun to warm up. While they were warming up, Sam snuck into the building to try to find the “mysterious person.” Sam found a room with a sign that read OFFICE, so he assumed that was where the “mysterious person” was. He cautiously entered the room, but there were no guards guarding it!

Sam walked toward the desk.

Suddenly a net dropped from above onto Sam! Sam tried to get free, but since he was so old and weak, he just flopped to the ground. Sam heard a voice that he recognized. When he turned around, he saw his evil brother named Dean! Sam was speechless. He did not know what to say. Just then,

Jordan came in and rammed Sam's brother into the wall with his head. Jordan helped Sam out of the net, and then Sam told Jordan that the guy he rammed was his brother.

Chapter Eight: Life is Back to Normal

When Sam's brother woke up, he challenged Jordan to an obstacle course in order to get out. The obstacle course included razor-sharp spikes, blazing hot wrecking balls, and trap doors that open every second! Jordan accepted the challenge, and he walked toward the course.

Suddenly, Sam rushed in, grabbed his brother, and stuffed him into a brown leather bag. Jordan and Sam raced out of the tall, gray building with the brown leather bag. All the residents, Sam, and Jordan piled into a nearby abandoned van and drove off to the village. At the village, Sam decided to punish his evil brother! So, he went to his secret hut to grab a bottle of sleep gas. Then he built a hut with a brick wall and a steel door. Once again, he took his brother out of the leather bag and put him into the hut. That hut was hidden and locked, so no bad guys or guards could free him. Sam then went back to the village, and, since then, Arthur guarded the village. Sam invited him to stay at the village as a guard. Sam hired pet caretakers for Jordan, so Jordan was living the best life ever. The village lived happily ever after!



Anoop Bath was born in Hillsboro, Oregon. He is nine years old, has a younger brother who is five years old, and a baby sister who is one. His favorite animal is the African Lion. He also loves building Lego sets at home. His favorite video game is Minecraft, and his favorite book is Fantastic Mr. Fox by Roald Dahl. The reason behind his writing interest is that he loves dinosaurs, and he knows a lot of facts about them.

Congratulations Anoop!

Jimmy Jim's Adventure

By Kelvin Merino Varona

Long ago, in a wonderful village where life was full of magic, there lived a boy named Jimmy. His family had just moved into the village, and they were very poor. Jimmy's mother always believed in him, in whatever Jimmy said, and Jimmy once told his mom that he will try to help them get rich.

One day, while walking on a bridge over a river, he found a magnificent flower and stole it for his mother. Then, he saw the flower move side to side and—

POW!

Jimmy had turned into an evil, greedy fox.

After a few days, he ran into a village and saw a rich man. Jimmy bit the man to try and steal his money... but the man caught him and put him in a cage. Now, the greedy fox, who used to be Jimmy, was stuck and couldn't move! After a few minutes, he saw the man was trying to cook him.

In the afternoon he luckily got out of the cage by using his strong teeth and realized he was in a forest. After a bit of searching for someone who knew why he was turned into a fox, he ran into a blind man and stole all his money. He did not know the man was an evil and powerful wizard—

POW!

He was turned into a small mouse.

Finally, Jimmy was trying to look for food and discovered a stone, which he didn't realize was magical. Angry that he didn't find food, he kicked the stone and—

POW!

A magical genie popped out and said, “I will grant you three wishes because you found me.” The first wish he granted was for him to be normal again. Next, he granted him to not be greedy anymore, and Jimmy’s final wish was for his family to never be poor again. “We really need it, and I’m sorry I was greedy,” Jimmy said, looking at the genie. The genie didn’t say a word and gave him a map instead, making Jimmy work for his riches.

As Jimmy was walking home, he learned to never be greedy, no matter how desperate he was to help his family. When he got home, he apologized to his family for making bad choices and told them he would always be honest when helping his family.



My name is Kelvin Merino Varona, and I am 10 years old. Outside of school, I love playing soccer, helping my mom, and playing video games. I first started to enjoy writing when I was in 2nd grade, and ever since then I've liked expressing my ideas and stories on paper!

Congratulations Kelvin!

The Intergalactic War

By Lincoln Kirkwood

“Everyone please evacuate.”

Okay, okay, let’s back up. I’m Colin, a British news reporter. So, 100 years ago, the Gorg was brought back from extinction. The Gorg lived on a decayed planet named Glorpeo. The Gorg are planet-eating monsters, and they’ve been trying to eat Earth for ages and have gotten pretty close. Like the time of the New York attack, but that’s for a different time.

Anyway, everyone is so scared of these things; it’s chaos. The military gave them all the nuclear weapons just because a baby got into their camp. A baby! Me personally, I would’ve just disregarded that.

Though, they are immune to anything except Hyperlight, which is only found on a planet named Rigma... I’m thinking too much about this. Anyway, if a Gorg pod ever lands here, I’ll be—

Ring, ring, ring!

“Wait, no way! I was just—okay. Okay. I’ll be there right away.”

“This is Colin Butterworth reporting from HQ news. There is a Mama Gorg right in front of Silverwood Secondary School. Everyone please evacuate London and all spaces within 25 miles. The S.W.A.T. team is coming with some Hyperlight. Please stay out of a 25-mile radius of London for at least the next hour and 30 minutes.”

Wow, that was crazy! I was just about to tell you that if there was a Gorg pod that landed, I would be right at the studio, reporting about it. I am glad I didn’t go to the scene and report it there. The Gorg on scene was aggressive, but not as bad as my time in school. I went to Silverwood, and that

principal still doesn't like me. Tomorrow I am covering a big news story. The Emperor of the World and the Gorg Leader are meeting to discuss the war.

The Next Morning

"This is Colin Butterworth reporting for HQ news on the scene above the planet Filx 9000, where the Empire of the World is talking to the Gorg leader about terms of Earth not being eaten."

"So, if you leave this planet alone, we will not destroy your tribe," said the Emperor of the World.

"Brr bl (No way)," said the Gorg leader.

"Hmm, fine. Then, we will go to war! At 9:45 A.M. on Sunday we will start," said the Emperor of the World.

"Bhhhh (fine)," said the Gorg leader.

"You've heard it here, folks. We are going to war with the Gorg. This is Colin Butterworth signing off. Be safe, Fletchlins!"

The War

"Alright folks, this is Colin Butterworth again reporting on the war. We are at the planet Filx 9000 again. The war is about to commence between the Gorgs of Glorpeo and the Fletchings of Earth." CUT!

We are not humans; we are Fletchilings, which are aliens that took over Earth 50,000 years ago, and our weakness is chromite! Chromite is a radioactive mineral that is found on Glorpeo. ROLLING!

"The war has commenced. The Gorgs are winning with their massive supply of Chromite. They have gathered 13 tons of chromite since declaring war. They have made bombs of chromite in secret." CUT!

The crazy thing is they didn't know that Chromite was our weakness. Gorgs use chromite in their muffin recipes. One day a Gorg soldier was eating a muffin and dropped it, and that one muffin took out a whole fleet of Fletchlings! **ROLLING!**

"Muffins flying everywhere! Mayday, mayday, mayday! We are already down 50 men! I'm just getting word from the Emperor of the World: we are bringing out our secret weapon. Prepare to be amazed, folks! Here comes a cargo ship dropping Hyperlight weapons and swords."

That's right, folks, we found a way to process nuclear waste into Hyperlight. Then, we made Condensed Hyperlight. We are starting to come back! They may have muffins, but we have great iron swords. Yes, we are slicing their muffins and their forces. We have finally won the war!

The Next Day

This is Colin Butterworth reporting from HQ News: we won the war. And we made too much Hyperlight, so we made Hyperlight grapes. We figured out that Hyperlight is filled with healthy minerals for us. If you want some Hyperlight grapes, go to Bob & Earl's Great Grapes. Now, we will move to Filx 9000 in honor of our victory.

The End.



Lincoln is a 4th grader at Hunsberger Elementary School. He is enrolled in the SWAS program. He has a younger brother. When he is not in school, he loves to play board games, card games, and sports outdoors. He also enjoys video games. Lincoln is currently reading the Harry Potter series and is enjoying it.

Congratulations Lincoln!

Just Do It

By Margaret “Maggie” Reed

The ball flies towards my face; I duck out of the way. The crowd groans. “Come on!” They all say, “She could have hit that!”

STRIKE!

The umpire calls. *Dang it!* I think to myself. Another ball comes barreling at me. I swing. I miss.

“Ashley, pay attention! Eyes on the prize! Stop being absolutely horrible!” The crowd says in unison.

Tears fill my eyes. *I’ll get it this time!* I shout, my voice breaking. The ball comes flying. I miss it again.

“Ughhhh! Get this kid out!” The crowd shouts.

I start to cry. I throw my bat and run out the gate and towards my house. I hear the crowd say, “you know, she’s really whiney for a 13 year old.” But, I don’t care. I just keep running.

* * *

My mom walks in my room and sighs when she sees me huddled in a corner, tears streaming down my face.

“Honey, why’d you run off like that, you were doing great.”

“No I wasn’t!” I yelled at her.

She walked over to me as I burst into tears. “Ashley,” she says, “even if you weren’t perfect, you can always try again.”

“No!” I yelled. “I’m not going back! EVER!”

he—” “Sweetie, here’s what you need to do. I know a guy and

“NO!” I interrupted. I didn’t want to hear it. I was done with softball.

“Ashley listen to me. I know a guy, and he does training and help with sports, and he will help you get better. I am going to give him a call. He will help you get better at softball. You can try to play.” She says to me.

I look up at her. “You really think I can get better?” I say, my voice cracking.

“No honey, I *know* you’ll get better. Now, get up, wipe your nose, and I will call him right now.”

* * *

“Here we go,” I whisper to myself. I’m at a practice for softball. This guy is... not helpful. How is he going to help me get better at softball? The worst part is mom is making me practice for a month before I can quit softball. He throws a pitch, I miss the ball.

“Maybe try to swing faster,” he suggested. He throws another ball. I swing really fast, and miss. “Okay. Try slower,” he said. This time I swung really slow, and missed...

“Okay, uhm, a little faster.”

I look up. I’m done with this. I throw my bat at the dirt floor. “PICK a side dude! What do you want from me!” I yell.

He looks over at me and sighs. “If you keep crashing out like that, you’re never gonna get ahead. So, pick up your bat, and try again.” He was *not* asking anymore. But, I didn’t care.

“No.” I said. “I’m done with this dumb sport.”

He gave me a sharp look that meant: *Don’t test me little girl*. I pick up the bat and got in a swinging position. Then, he said very softly, “Just remember to breathe.” I listened. He

throws the pitch, and I swing. I close my eyes and hear a loud clink, and then a thunk. I opened my eyes.

I hit the ball! I hit the ball!

“Great job!” He said. “Now, let’s do that again.” He threw another ball. I swung and hit it again. “You’re doing wonderful!” He yelled. He threw a couple more pitches, and I hit them all! Before I knew, an hour had passed, and my mom walked in. “Hey sweetie, ready to go?” She asked.

“It’s already time to go?” I asked.

“Yes, sweetie. Come on, get your stuff together,” she said. Then, she walked over to my coach whose name was Damien. I heard them chatting in the distance. Damien was saying how I was improving and, in just a couple more classes, I would be ready to play again. Mom smiled and said she was excited for me to play again. Then, they said goodbye, and mom walked over to me. I grabbed my gear bag and headed over to her.

“Did you have fun?” She asked.

“Yes!” I yelled.

“That’s good, honey,” she responded.

* * *

A couple classes had gone by. Damien said I really improved and should be ready to play again. I was so excited to play. My mom was driving me to class. “Honey, this is your last class before you can play again.”

“Really?” I shouted.

“Really.” She said back. We had just arrived at the place where I do my classes.

“Bye mom!” I shouted before I jumped out of the car. I ran into the batting cages. “Hi Damien!” I said excitedly.

“Ya ready squirt?” He asked.

“Yup!” I said.

I threw on my helmet and grabbed my bat. I ran over. He threw a pitch and I hit it. “Dinger!” He yelled. I smiled. I hit a few more dingers, and a couple hours later class was over. I gathered my stuff and ran to my mom.

“Bye Damien!” I screamed.

“Bye Ashley!” He yelled. Mom and I got in the car.

“Sweetie, I have a surprise for you,” she said.

“What is it?” I asked.

“You start softball tomorrow!” She added.

“Really? Yay!” I said.

“Yes honey.”

* * *

I finally started softball again. It was the championship game, and my team had slammed through all the other games. I was up to bat and I was nervous, but then I remembered what Damien had told me. *Just breathe.* I thought. I took a deep breath, and got in my swinging stance. The pitcher threw the ball, and I hit it!

Oh my god.

I dropped my bat and ran as fast as I could. I made it to first base—

“KEEP going Ashley!” My coach yelled. I ran to second base.

“Ashley go!” The crowd cheered. I kept going. I got to

third base.

“Go home! Go home!” My coach yelled. I ran to home base. The crowd cheered loudly. My team runs over to me and cheers my name. We won the game because of my dinger. Everyone was yelling my name, not in anger, but in happiness. I was the reason we won. My team and I went to get pizza as a celebration for winning. We were sitting at the table eating when my coach asked:

“Ashley, we’ve all been wondering, how did you get so good? What’s your secret?”

“Well,” I said. “Honestly, all it is, is just to breathe.”

* * *



My name is Maggie. I'm only 10 and have dreamed of being an author since a young age. My inspiration for this book is my personal experiences. I play softball and started off with a lack of confidence. After 5 years of practicing, I'm better at softball. The lesson is: only when you stop trying, do you truly fail.

Congratulations Maggie!

Alice and the Magical Witch

By Sofia Ruelas

Long ago in the tall mountains, lived a mean princess named Alice. Alice lived in a bright gold castle. Alice was beautiful, but she was also very mean. She was mean to poor people, other kingdoms, and villagers. She kicked and screamed if someone didn't do as she wanted or her way of doing things. Even if only asking, she would be greedy and mean like no other.

When Alice was walking through her village, she encountered a wise and poor man asking for either food, money, or clothes. When the poor man asked Alice to offer something, Alice burst out screaming, "How dare you ask a future queen to offer something?!" Alice added, "You should be ashamed of yourself."

The poor man with sad eyes looked down, feeling hopeless. And once the princess wasn't around, under the wind he whispered, "What a mean princess." Then, the poor man just walked away to ask for goods in another place, away from Princess Alice.

The next day, on a sunny and beautiful day, she ran into a rich and handsome prince named Jacob with his horse from his powerful and wise kingdom. Alice, out of greed, was asking to be his bride, how much money he had, and if he had beautiful, expensive gowns for her. The prince, disgusted with her greediness, said he had already found someone. Once again she screamed and kicked him three times and his horse. While the horse and prince were startled, Alice had walked away angry and secretly, without looking back an inch.

One day, she was on her morning stroll through the forest when all of a sudden she found a lady sitting down. She was doing something Alice couldn't decipher. When Alice saw her face, she found out that the lady was a magical witch who granted three wishes of any kind. Alice was about to complain

that the witch was in her way when the witch said, “I will grant three wishes but—”

“Gold, powerful powers, and a rich handsome prince!” blurted Alice. When Alice thought the witch was going to grant the wishes, she turned Alice into a frog instead. “Because of your greed and rudeness, you will be punished,” the witch said as she turned her into a frog.

Alice was sad.

“Oh please, magical witch! Please turn me back into a human!” said Alice desperately.

The witch kindly and peacefully turned Alice back into a human with a wave of her wand. Just when Alice was going to run off, the witch said, “You’re a human now, but if you are mean again, you’ll never be human again.”

Alice accepted and went to her kingdom. When Alice arrived, she apologized to everyone she had hurt or had been disrespectful to. At that moment, the witch arrived and gave a chance to have 3 wishes again. Instead of asking for gold, she only wanted peace, love, and health. The witch made her wishes come true even if it wasn’t for her. At that moment Alice realized that “kindness is rewarded.”

So, Alice was never mean again.



My name is Sofia Ruelas. I am 11 years old, and I'm a 5th grader at Mater Academy of Northern Nevada. Outside of school, I enjoy creating art and playing soccer. I had a lot of fun writing this story in class, and I'm excited for you to read it.

Congratulations Sofia!

An Unfortunate Camping Trip

By Emmett Herrera

I'm one of those kids whose family always stayed home on weekends, and then all of a sudden my Mom decided to turn that around. Out of the blue she said, "Come on guys, we're going on a camping trip!" Quickly, everyone started packing food, water, clothes, and sleeping bags. Afterwards, Mom checked if we had everything.

"Water, food, clothes, sleeping bags, generator, hand warmers?"

And Dad said back to Mom, "Check, check, check, check, check, check!"

It took 30 minutes to get to Stampede Reservoir so I decided to take a nap. When we got there I pretended to act like I was still asleep so I didn't have to help set up. Mom tried to tickle me in my tickle spot, but luckily that was covered up.

Then, to help my mom out, my little brother, Jack, punched me in the stomach... I screamed, "OW!" As a punishment, Mom gave Jack a time-out in the trailer, which wasn't fair at all because it was more like Jack now didn't need to help with setting up. So, it was just me, Mom, and Dad setting up. I guess that my "pretending-to-sleep-plan" didn't work out well.

The next day Mom said, "Come on guys, we're going on a hike. And grab your swim trunks!" We started a two-hour hike that would take us to a lake. The hike was a lot of fun! Soon, we saw a snake trailing us, so we walked faster and got to the lake. But the lake wasn't much fun. The water was murky, and there were a lot of sharp rocks everywhere.

That's what we did on our second day.

* * *

Today was the day we were gonna leave, but we wanted to ride our bikes since we brought them. So, we took our bikes off our bike rack.

Jack screamed, "AHHH! Spiduh!" We went over to look; it was a little black widow hanging off a web. Dad went to grab a stick. He grabbed the spider and web, then flung it away. And that's when we saw an egg sac...

So, Jack had to ride with me on my bike, which was unfortunate for me. Once we were done riding our bikes, Jack wanted to ride my bike by himself. We told him he couldn't, but then he started bawling his eyes out for the next half hour. None of us wanted to deal with him right now, so we decided to put Jack in his car seat and drive home.

Sometimes when my family goes on vacation, we might not have the luck of the draw...

The End



I was nine when writing this story. I wrote this story because I thought it would be funny. I like to play baseball, and my favorite color is red. I want to thank my vice principal, Ms. Torrey, and my teacher, Mrs. Dupont, for helping me to succeed in this contest.

Congratulations Emmett!

Sakura and the Dragon's Village

By Mieko Jimetta

Long ago, in a village, there lived a kind 12-year-old girl named Sakura. Her village was very poor, but the people used teamwork to solve their problems.

One day, when it was a very cold rainy day, Sakura and her cat Momo were in their grandparent's hut, and they noticed that the clouds looked like they were holding a very dangerous sickness that could drop down onto the village. Right when she was about to tell the village's dragon about the clouds, it was too late. The sickness has dropped down onto the village, making everyone sick except the ones who noticed the clouds. The illness made the infected unable to walk.

The villagers predicted that they were never going to walk again. However, Sakura's grandfather and grandmother came up to Sakura and told her that there was only one way to cure the village.

They told of the legend of the magic dragon who had cured 100,000 illnesses in a village 3 times, which were never cured by other dragons. After Sakura listened to the legend, she decided that she was going to ask the dragon to *please* heal the village—the village and her family were the only treasures to her. Sakura's grandparents told her that the dragon's village was at a place no one knew. The grandparents only knew where the path was to the dragon's village.

As Sakura was going to the mountain of Lost Village, she came across a village that gave magic to every polite person who spoke from the heart. Sakura gave the village flowers that gave joy to the people who were mad, sad, nervous, and even to the people who were cranky, all without getting a bit scared herself.

The villagers and the village's dragon decided that Sakura could be trusted, so they gave Sakura 3 powers to use. Sakura was delighted, and she was so happy to get 3 powers from the village when she remembered about her village's illness. Sakura asked them which way to go. That's when the

whole village pointed the same way the travelers told Sakura.

The people always pointed to the sunrise and told her that “the sunrise would tell you the truth, so keep going the same way until it finally tells you.” Sakura always thought about what they were saying, but she never knew the answer. Sakura was curious but kept going the way they told her, and finally she came to a huge mountain, and Sakura knew that this mountain led her to the Lost Village where the dragon lives.

When Sakura walked into the huge mountain, she felt uncomfortable and told Momo not to get off her shoulder. Sakura kept on walking until she saw a bush move and a huge coyote came out of it. Sakura was so terrified and thought that she was going to die until the coyote started to cry.

The coyote wanted to talk to people, but people always ran away from him. Sakura listened to the coyote, and then another coyote came out of the bush, and they both asked Sakura to please turn them into humans so they could go to the village. Sakura thought for a moment, and then she told them that if they would help her get to the dragon’s village, she would make them into humans.

The coyotes were happy to help and happy to become humans, and they built a wagon for Sakura. The coyotes started to push the wagon as fast as they could towards the hill to go down the mountain to the dragon’s village. The coyotes introduced themselves. One of the coyotes introduced himself as Cloud, and the other girl coyote told Sakura that “my name is Sky.” Sakura felt very comfortable and happy around the coyote twins. Soon, Sakura, the twins, and Momo finally saw the dragon’s village.

They finally came to the village and entered the gate, and the first thing they saw was so many dragons in every size. Sakura was amazed by how many dragons there were and so many colors in the village.

Sakura and the team saw a huge castle in the middle of the village and saw so many soldiers looking at the dragons around the castle. The team slowly walked around the castle, looking around for a place to enter. Finally, they found the gate, but the dragons didn’t let them into the castle without

permission. Suddenly, a deep voice came from the castle, saying, “Who would be willing to meet me?”

Sakura answered, “I would be willing to meet you to recover my village.”

The dragon paused and then answered, “I give you a task to do in one hour.”

Sakura felt worried, and the dragon told her to make a brocade of a dragon holding an emerald. Sakura had never made a brocade before in her life and started to cry. Suddenly, three baby dragons appeared in front of her and started to talk to her.

They asked, “What are you crying about? You have magic and you can use that to help yourself!” Sakura, with a flick of the wrist, made the brocade and gave it to the dragon.

The dragon was delighted, and the dragon made her wish come true. Sakura quickly got on the wagon leading back home, and the wagon started to move fast through the wind, and she got home the next day. The villagers were delighted to walk and to see Sakura again.

Sakura learned that true kindness gets rewarded even if it is only a little bit of kindness like her acts for the village, coyotes, and the dragon.



My name is Mieko Jimetta. I am 10 years old, and I'm proud to be a 5th grader at Mater Academy of Northern Nevada. Outside of school, I love to read Japanese comics and use my creativity to make all kinds of things, such as scarves, dolls, and paper crafts. One cool fact about me is that I can read, write, and speak Japanese, which is something that makes me really unique!

Congratulations Mieko!

